

Germany: State elections threaten Merz

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【メール原文】

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Germany

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Upcoming state elections will threaten Merz's leadership next year

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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State elections in the north-eastern state of Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania on 20 September will hand Chancellor Friedrich Merz's conservative party (CDU) a disastrous result and will lead to a further increase in internal anti-Merz sentiment.

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Merz will likely stay in office until at least the spring of 2027, but is at risk of being replaced by an internal CDU challenger over the course of next year.

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Although Merz is at risk over the medium term, his government is not—the SPD is more likely to vote in a Merz alternative than walk out of the coalition.

Elections in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania (MWP) and Berlin will see a doubling of the far-right AfD's vote in both states, but no AfD path to power, as the anti-AfD firewall holds. This distinguishes this year's last political tests for Merz's government from the vote in Saxony-Anhalt on 6 September, the results of which will almost certainly yield an AfD-led government, potentially made possible by individual defectors from other parties.

In MWP, Prime Minister Manuela Schwesig will likely remain in power despite SPD losses, a victory that will position her well as a possible successor to the SPD's leadership in late 2027. The AfD will likely come out strongest here, but won't find the necessary support from other parties to turn the pole position into a coalition government.

The CDU will see a disastrous result in MWP, but will narrowly avoid dropping out of parliament altogether, a key signpost for national politics. For Merz, the fate of MWP's local CDU will be a crucial result after disgruntlement about his performance as chancellor has built up within his own party over the past months. The possible (and historically unprecedented) drop below the 5% threshold in MWP could trigger an anti-Merz wave within the CDU, putting him at risk as party chairman and, ultimately, as chancellor. While such an outcome is unlikely over the next six months, Merz is at acute risk of being replaced should a suitable challenger emerge after another set of state elections in April 2027.

In the city-state of Berlin, the elections will likely result in a CDU-led government (55% probability), but poll numbers are extremely tight, and Berlin's local political scene is too splintered and volatile to assign greater confidence to that outcome. Weak results for both the CDU and SPD will very likely make government formation highly complicated, if not impossible. In addition to dealing another blow to Merz, it is likely to trigger a heated debate within the SPD about the party's future course at the national level, a debate that could put party co-chairs Lars Klingbeil and Bärbel Bas at risk of being replaced next year.

Regardless of these election results, the debate over how to deal with the AfD within Germany's political system will intensify. Both within and outside the conservative camp, the firewall strategy of boycotting the AfD and rejecting any form of cooperation with them is seen as a failure given the party's ever-increasing share of the vote. The CDU will be most affected by this debate, as many conservative voters tend to prefer cooperation with the AfD over coalitions with left-leaning parties. But there are also voices in the Left Party and elsewhere that suggest a strategic rethink on how to handle the AfD. The firewall is not at risk in the short term, but will become increasingly hard to sustain as Germany's party landscape continues to splinter and readjust. Similarly, calls for an AfD ban have intensified in recent months, a legally complicated procedure that bears a considerable risk of backfiring before the German Constitutional Court, which has set a high bar on such interventions.

No further state elections are scheduled in Germany until the spring, giving both the CDU and SPD leaderships a brief reprieve. But tensions will run high again ahead of votes in three western states in April 2027: Saarland and Schleswig-Holstein on 18 April, and North Rhine-Westphalia (NRW) on 25 April. The city-state of Bremen will follow on 30 May, with the larger Lower Saxony on 26 September. The NRW vote will likely be crucial for Merz's political future, as a good result for the state's CDU prime minister, Hendrik Wüst, would likely position him as Merz's biggest internal rival and most likely successor as chancellor.

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